

Understanding and Balancing Trade-offs of Visibility in Support Requests

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ABSTRACT

This study delves into support-seeking behaviors in local support exchange networks, where a lack of support requests has been commonly found in prior studies. Focusing on three widely adopted approaches to making support requests in these networks, our research employed a scenario-based approach, presenting participants with three situations requiring instrumental support. Participants were asked to choose and rationalize their preferred method of request for each scenario. The study reveals that preferences varied due to factors like urgency, privacy, social image, and control over the situation. These findings highlight significant trade-offs between different approaches to asking for help. We suggest design implications aimed at facilitating more effective and psychologically comfortable support-seeking behaviors on local support exchange platforms.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing.

KEYWORDS

Support exchange, help-seeking behaviors, local support exchange, scenario-based design

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1 INTRODUCTION

With the pervasiveness of online technologies connecting people to one another, the spectrum of sources from which individuals can seek and receive support has significantly expanded. While numerous forms of online support exchange have been paid attention to in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), there exists a specific research strand on behaviors within geographically-bounded contexts [38], ranging from food sharing [21], tool libraries [18, 19],

and general goods and service exchanges [8, 35, 47]. Local support exchange platforms enable individuals to “ask for a cup of sugar” and other resources and services from nearby strangers, effectively bridging otherwise distinct local networks and relationships. Geographically bounded support exchanges can strengthen community bonds and trust that are challenging to cultivate in large-scale social exchange systems [35, 47]. They also enable a broader range of instrumental, tangible support due to physical proximity, not limited to informational or emotional support.

However, asking for instrumental support or support from strangers, although nearby, can be daunting, often accompanied by feelings of shame and embarrassment [1, 42]. Indeed, numerous prior studies on local support exchange platforms found a significant lack of support requests compared to offers [8, 14, 21, 24, 34, 35, 46, 54, 55]. This disparity highlights a significant research gap in understanding how support request mechanisms for stressful situations that require instrumental support from strangers should be designed. In this work, we explore preferences and perceptions around different methods of making a support request and use these insights to inform design strategies that could alleviate the psychological discomfort associated with seeking help.

We contrasted three common approaches to making support requests on local support exchange platforms and used a scenario-based approach to immerse participants in situations requiring instrumental support. We presented three scenarios to each participant and asked them to choose and justify their preferred method of asking for help for each scenario. There was no one-size-fits-all approach, and participants favored each approach for distinct reasons, including privacy concerns, social image, the ability to communicate details with precision, and control over the situation. These preferences implied trade-offs between different approaches. Based on our findings, we derive design implications that can balance these trade-offs to facilitate support-seeking behaviors.

2 LITERATURE REVIEW

There are individual platforms dedicated to local support exchanges, such as timebanks, Pumpipumpe¹, and Olio²; however, not all communities for local support exchanges leverage bespoke platforms but instead rely on widely accessible platforms, including Facebook, WhatsApp, and Google Docs [9, 10, 32], which could benefit from already existing extensive user bases. Attracting a critical mass of users, the standard cold start problem in social computing, is key to the sustainability of support exchange platforms [13, 48]. Given that geographical boundaries inherently limit the potential user

¹<https://pumpipumpe.ch/en/home-en/>

²<https://olioapp.com/en/>

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pool, leveraging commonly available tools can offer a significant advantage in overcoming this challenge.

Support requests made through such platforms can generally be divided into three categories [32]: (1) **private requests** with standardized templates on Google or Airtable Forms, where support seekers' details such as contact information and needs can be filled out. Moderators review submitted requests and match support seekers with helpers; (2) **public indirect requests** involve support seekers communicating their needs to moderators, who then disseminate this information through posts (e.g., Facebook) to other community members; (3) **public direct requests**, where individuals directly post and ask for their needs from the community. Among these methods, the first has the least, and the third has the greatest level of *visibility*, a social media affordance with which the user believes how easily the content can be found and viewed by others [17].

Levels of visibility can affect disclosure behaviors in online communities [39]. Platforms where posts are highly visible to others may raise privacy concerns, deterring users from sharing personal distress despite potential support benefits [7]. Fear of negative judgement and stigma attached to disclosing distress and asking for help can increase with higher visibility of help-seeking behaviors [16, 31, 50]. However, if others' distress disclosures are visible as well, individuals can find it psychologically easier to disclose their struggles and seek support [3]. The second approach we introduced, public indirect requests, involves asking for help through a third party, which Lampinen [34] identified as a promising strategy for fostering beneficial support exchanges, as it can reduce negative feelings of being indebted to others' reciprocity and reduce the chances of harming one's social image [5]. Indirect requests can also increase potential helpers' trust in support seekers; if they believe that moderators, who help keep scammers out of the community, trust support seekers, their trust in moderators would be extended to support seekers [12].

Although concerns about exploitation by freeriders in support networks do exist, many are reluctant to ask for help, resulting in a scarcity of support requests on local support exchange platforms [8, 21, 54], aligning with HCI studies on challenges over disclosing one's distress [3, 7]. Prior studies found that this hesitancy to ask for help stems from concerns around burdening [18, 35] and dependent on others [14], the avoidance of feeling indebted and obligated to give back [35, 47], and lack of interpersonal trust and privacy concerns [25]. We contribute to the literature on support-seeking behaviors on local support exchange platforms by extending its scope to preferences and perceptions around the three common approaches to making support requests.

3 METHOD

We were interested in preferences and perceptions regarding the three methods of making a support request in local support exchange networks introduced in Section 2. We randomly showed our participants three scenarios that require instrumental support and asked them to choose a method they preferred and explain why they chose the particular method for each scenario. This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board.

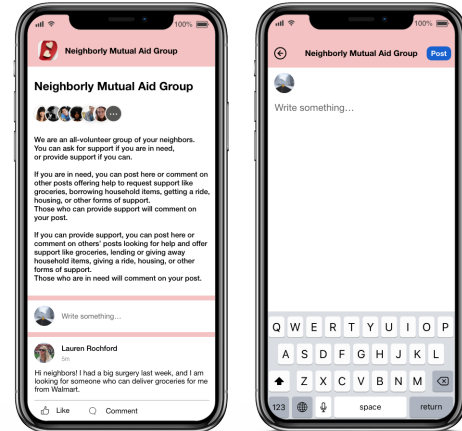


Figure 1: Highly Visible Support Request

3.1 Scenarios and Interventions

A scenario provides concrete examples to stimulate participants to envision a presented system and how they will use it [44]. Each scenario required different instrumental support: money, child care, and a place to stay. For instance, one scenario detailed the need for temporary housing relocation due to unexpected disruptions in home utilities for three days and a lack of affordable accommodation options. To immerse participants in the scenario, we used a first-person perspective. Three scenarios are specified in the Appendix.

Each support request interface detailed its handling process, with an example of others' requests: low visibility involved seeker-helper matching by moderators; moderate visibility used moderator-posted requests; and high visibility allowed direct user posts. Depending on the visibility level, interfaces featured different forms for participants to enter requests: a standard form for low visibility, a message to the moderator for moderate, and a general post field for high. All three interfaces are provided in Figure ?? in the Appendix, while the intervention with high visibility is provided as an example in Figure 1. We assume that participants were well-acquainted with each interface and its corresponding method of handling support requests, as this was a part of the larger study where our participants actively engaged in crafting messages asking for help in the given support request interfaces, which were presented three times, respectively.

3.2 Survey

The survey was conducted using Qualtrics and utilized its feature to prevent multiple submissions. To deter bot entries, we included a reCAPTCHA and a honeypot question that is invisible to humans. Responses to the honeypot question indicated a bot, leading to exclusion from the study. At the start of the survey, participants answered screening questions that covered demographics, the duration of support group membership, and participation frequency. We excluded those who are (1) not in any neighbor support group, (2) under 18, and (3) outside the United States. Participants were then directed to the main questionnaire, where three scenarios and a selection of the interventions were presented in a random sequence to avoid any order bias. Participants were asked to choose which

intervention they preferred to seek support for each scenario and to articulate the reasons behind their choices.

3.3 Participants

The Qualtrics survey link was shared on Facebook's local neighbor support groups in the United States, with prior approval from the group moderators. These groups were chosen for recruitment because Facebook is recognized as the most widely used, publicly available platform for local sharing exchange communities in the United States [32]. We reviewed the responses and then excluded those that (1) failed the screening criteria, (2) were identified as bots, (3) were duplicates, and (4) were of low quality, with one-word responses, random characters, or irrelevant to the given scenario. Finally, the sample included 93 participants, consisting of 47 males and 46 females; 76% self-identified as Caucasian/White; 64% had at least a two-year college degree; 57% were aged between 18 and 24; and 42% had a household income ranging from \$50,000 to \$74,999. Among the 93 participants, 64 gave an explanation for why they preferred the intervention they chose.

3.4 Qualitative Analysis

We performed inductive thematic analysis [11] on the support requests composed by participants under various conditions of support request visibility. Initially, the first and second authors familiarized themselves with the data and independently developed initial codes using Dovetail. They then shared, reviewed, and refined their initial coding (e.g., adding, removing, or integrating codes) and performed axial coding to consolidate relevant codes under overarching themes. A consensus on codes and themes was reached through iterative discussions; each section of the findings represents the themes and elaborates on associated codes (e.g., immediacy, large audience, precise information delivery).

4 FINDINGS

Participants most commonly preferred making an indirect post via a moderator with moderate visibility ($n=106$), compared to high ($n=85$) and low visibility ($n=88$) request options. They favored each intervention for different factors it provided for effectiveness in getting support, convenience in asking for help, privacy, and community belonging.

4.1 Effectiveness in Getting Support

Participants felt they could receive support more promptly through more visible support requests ($n=16$ for high visibility; $n=14$ moderate visibility) compared to the low visibility condition. However, those who preferred the high visibility intervention noted that the other interventions could potentially incur delays from moderators responding late, the wait time for a response from helpers assigned by moderators, or the possibly limited availability of these designated helpers:

“going through the moderator might be a little bit late, for he/she might be busy when the message gets to him/her before sending to the group.” [P33, High]

“it is the fastest and most efficient method available...allows me to get help from the group without having to make an appointment or wait for someone to respond.” [P52, High]

“if someone else had already used up all of their time...or if there were other circumstances preventing them from being able to meet with me immediately...then...my request for support might not be fulfilled until later in the day or even tomorrow?which is not always ideal when you need something as soon as possible.” [P62, High]

Nine participants attributed the likelihood of receiving immediate support in the highly visible request setting to the larger audience of potential helpers. Some mentioned that this could result in a broader range of options in offers: *“I would get faster response as a lot of persons would see the request...and I'll get a variety of choices”* [P16, High]. As support requests will still be publicly made in the moderately visible request setting, just not by support seekers but by moderators, participants shared similar comments: *“Post for everyone to see and have variety of help”* [P43, Moderate].

However, some participants stated that due to a request being targeted to *“someone who had already signed up”* [P55, Low] in the low visibility condition and due to it being *“a more personal way of reaching out for support...it is less likely to be ignored by members of the group”* [P56, Low]. They also found that a moderator linking them to the targeted helper provides a sense of assurance that their request will be met: *“I would like to go through the moderator, because he/she might know the people who can actually help me out with the help I'm seeking for.”* [P33, Low]. Moreover, owing to a personal approach to asking for help, some expected increased empathy and a favorable response to their requests: *“easier for others to empathize and offer assistance.”* [P39, Low]; *“I can talk directly...about what's going on and make sure that the person on the other end...understands my situation.”* [P62, Low]

4.2 Convenience

20 participants perceived the lowest visibility intervention to be easy and convenient to ask for help. This preference was often attributed to the standardized, predefined form that was available in this condition: *“it is easier to keep track of all the information that needs to be shared”* [P55, Low]; *“This is a way to sort my needs and ask for help.”* [P27, Low].

Due to having a predefined form ready in this condition, participants believed more precise information regarding their needs could be conveyed: *“This allows us to reduce the risk of miscommunication and misunderstanding”* [P54, Low]. They perceived it would be easier for others to understand their requests well, which could increase the likelihood of getting support: *“It's easier for others to help when they know exactly what's needed”* [P39, Low].

In a similar vein, 17 participants preferred the moderately visible intervention for its real-time interaction with a moderator, which facilitated the immediate provision of any missing information for their requests: *“If there are any issues with my request, I will be able to respond quickly and fix any problems that may arise”* [P63, Moderate]. Due to such interactivity, participants believed they could more accurately convey the details of their needs and emotions, e.g., *“this is the best way to give the most accurate and detailed information about what I need help...It's also easier for me to convey my emotions”* [P56, Moderate]. Such real-time interactions also increased the sense of comfort: *“it allows me to see the person I'm talking to, which helps make me more comfortable.”* [P59, Moderate].

On the other hand, 14 participants preferred the direct approach of the highly visible intervention, describing it as being more *“direct*

and easier” [P40, High], “simpler and more convenient” [P50, High], and “straightforward” [P37, High]. This preference is attributed to the ability of support seekers to personally post their requests, granting them “more control over the situation” [P51, High]. This level of control was perceived to make support exchange processes more “predictive” [P6, High]: “It’s easier because I’ll just have to post something and wait for the responses. This way, I’ll see if I can get the help I need” [P46, High].

4.3 Privacy vs. Community Belonging

Compared to the highly visible condition where posts are made directly by support seekers, several participants preferred less visible requests for privacy concerns (n=17 for low visibility; n=9 for moderate visibility), e.g., “more private” [P2, Low]; “make sure I’m safe” [P15, Low]; “I don’t want anyone to know my identity” [P28, Moderate]; “There is a sense of security with the involvement of third party” [P42, Moderate]. In a similar vein, some of them felt that the highly visible condition posed a risk to their privacy, as their distress could be publicly disclosed in too much detail in the comment section when arranging support exchanges: “I would have to deal with the potential for people responding with questions or comments that risk revealing too much about my own personal situation” [P60, Low]. Choosing to remain less visible was more evident when financial needs were involved: “Since it’s money matter, i’ll use this method to direct my request at a specific person in the group instead of the public.” [P40, Low]. The increased privacy afforded by less visible formats was perceived as a means to alleviate concerns about social image and the fear of negative judgments: “you can get the information you need without having to worry about what other people might think of your request for help” [P54, Moderate]. Such alleviated concerns can enable individuals to more openly disclose their distress: “it allows me to be more open about my situation without fear of being judged by someone who knows me personally” [P51, Low].

A field for phone numbers included in the low-visibility intervention elicited varied reactions among participants. One participant preferred the moderately visible intervention because the participant “[didn’t] want to give out...contact information casually” [P29, Moderate]. In contrast, other participants favored the opportunity to share personal details in a private setting: “gives me a chance to give my clear details like phone number to be reached out to” [P32, Low], as they believed “others will be more clear about [their] purpose and [their] personal information, and both sides will trust each other” [P28, Low].

Although the high visibility of support requests could compromise privacy to some extent, some participants perceived it could give them an opportunity to connect with others in similar situations, thereby broadening the scope of support exchanges beyond themselves and including emotional support as well:

“I can...post updates, and get feedback from other people who are involved in the same situation as me...so that we can provide support for one another” [P61, High]
“if we were able to talk about it together and support each other, we might be able to feel better” [P53, High]
“because I believe in the power of community. I believe that when we come together, we can accomplish so much more than we could accomplish alone...be surrounded by people who have been where

I am and understand my struggle, and to have them guide me...I have benefited from the support of others in similar situations as me...it was such a relief to know that there were others out there who understood” [P57, High]

Participants also believed that they could learn how to offer support to others by observing others’ support exchanges in the highly visible condition: “I want to learn how...to be better at helping others. I think it will help me become a better friend and family member” [P58, High].

5 DISCUSSION

There were trade-offs when deciding between making a private or public request; while private requests can protect one’s privacy and self-esteem, they can also cause delays in having needs met and limit opportunities for supportive connections with others going through similar struggles. Participants favored the less visible and indirect interventions, owing to the more precise conveying of details under the guidance of predefined forms or interactions with moderators. Others, however, valued the enhanced control and predictability and the opportunity to learn from others’ support exchanges the highly visible interventions provided. We revisit our findings and suggest design implications to support psychological comfort during help-seeking.

5.1 Navigating the Trade-offs of Private and Public Requests

Some of our participants believed that sharing identifiable information (e.g., phone numbers, detailed accounts of their distress) in the less visible interventions could enhance mutual trust and help those who receive their request better understand their situation, potentially increasing the likelihood of getting a favorable response to their requests. The comfort and expected positive outcomes of sharing personal information in private settings align with findings from prior studies [4, 26, 28]. Another reason for a preference for the less visible interventions was pertinent to reducing concerns about social image and avoiding negative judgments that could threaten self-image [23], echoing prior studies [6, 27, 37, 41, 52]. As observed in Kang et al. [27], participants expressed apprehension about being judged by personal ties and felt more comfortable disclosing in private settings.

However, the choice between private and public requests entails trade-offs [27]. While private requests can help preserve privacy and self-image, public requests can lead to more immediate fulfillment of needs and positive interactions with others who have gone through similar challenges. To mitigate the belief that the risk of disclosing private information to a broader audience and threats to social image are concomitants of highly visible support requests, systems could offer support seekers increased visibility control. For instance, when support seekers reply to a comment on their highly visible requests, systems could allow them to choose whether their replies would be visible to everyone or only to the commented user to address privacy concerns. To alleviate concerns about social image in public settings, systems could allow support seekers to control the targeted audience of their requests, including the option to hide them from known connections.

Our findings also open up interesting areas for future research. Asking for help entails psychological barriers, including concerns about harming self-image [36] and revealing personal information [51]. These barriers are formally described as “social costs,” due to the interpersonal nature of support exchange. Although perceived social costs can deter individuals from asking for help, a sense of community belonging might mitigate their adverse effects on their willingness to seek support [2]. Our participants expected that increased empathy would lead to favorable responses to their requests. Similarly, individuals often believe that those with whom they have stronger ties will be more empathetic and less judgmental towards their support requests [15, 30, 53]. Future research should explore whether individuals with a stronger sense of community belonging are more likely to seek support despite perceived social costs. If community belonging is found to counterbalance the deterrent effects of social costs, platforms for support exchange could benefit from designs that can strengthen a sense of community.

5.2 Enhancing Perceived Control and Predictability of Support Requests

Some participants preferred the lowest-visibility intervention due to its standardized form that was readily available, which they felt allowed for the communication of more precise information. Similarly, interaction with a moderator in the moderate visibility condition was found beneficial, helping support seekers with comprehensive details necessary for requests. Additionally, participants favored interactivity in this condition, as they believed it enabled them to express their emotions and feel more comfortable discussing their distress. Our findings suggest that a chatbot that asks for details needed for support requests could be useful in conditions where interactions with moderators are not involved. For instance, in situations where support seekers post a request themselves, a chatbot can assist in formulating these requests, such as asking about the type of support they are looking for, when they would need their needs fulfilled, language or communication preferences, or any required accessibility considerations or accommodations. However, future research is vital to evaluate if support seekers experience a similar level of interactivity or emotional comfort with chatbots as they do with human moderators. Should this be the case, chatbots could complement the role of moderators in offering guidance for crafting support requests, alleviating delays caused by moderators’ response times.

Some participants felt that directly posting their support requests would grant them increased control over their situations. Increasing control in support exchange processes is crucial in that the reluctance to seek help can stem from a perceived lack of control over the situation [20, 40]. To increase support seekers’ perceived control in processes where moderators make requests on their behalf or match them with helpers, systems could be designed to allow seekers to view, edit, or delete their requests upon discussions with moderators and to control who could see their requests.

Another reason for preferring to directly post support requests was that participants believed support exchange processes would be more predictive, as they could expect whether their needs would be fulfilled. To enhance predictability in a setting where requests are matched to helpers or indirectly made by moderators, as in the least

or moderately visible conditions of our study, systems could show support seekers a progress bar. This feature could inform whether moderators have reviewed their requests, the progress in matching them with potential helpers, if the matched helper has reviewed and confirmed to meet their requests, and an estimated timeline for the helper to make contact. Additionally, overall predictability on support exchange platforms can be improved by providing support seekers with information such as the number of users who have submitted similar requests in the past and received support, as well as the average time taken for requests to be fulfilled. Such information can enhance collective efficacy, fostering the perception that the support exchange network operates effectively. Enhance collective efficacy can lead to increased participation, as people are more drawn into productive groups [29].

5.3 Facilitating Learning to Offer Support

Participants believed that highly visible support requests allowed them to improve their own ability to offer support to others in the community. This is pertinent to self-efficacy in providing support, which affects not only the willingness to help others [22, 43, 45] but also the willingness to ask for help. When individuals feel confident about their ability to contribute back to their community, they tend to feel more comfortable asking for help from it. This is due to a sense of reciprocity; individuals usually feel a need to return the help they receive [49], and may refrain from seeking help to avoid feelings of indebtedness or discomfort if they are unsure whether they could reciprocate to others [33, 47]. Future designs could show support seekers a list of prior successful support exchanges upon approval from corresponding seekers and helpers. This feature could help individuals understand community norms regarding how support is sought and provided and how they might contribute to the community in the future. The visibility of past successful support exchanges can psychologically ease the process of asking for help and enhance collective efficacy, potentially leading to increased participation [29]. This approach can create a more supportive and engaging community atmosphere, encouraging both giving and receiving help.

6 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

We performed a scenario-based study leveraging the three approaches to asking for help in online-mediated local support exchange networks to explore what technological features and values support seekers demand. First, we found the need to balance maintaining privacy to allow comfortable distress disclosures and immediately fulfilling needs. These findings suggest that platforms should offer support seekers visibility controls to address these trade-offs effectively. Second, we found the desire to deliver precise information with readily available guidance and interactivity, which suggests future research to evaluate the potential benefits of integrating chatbots that can interactively guide support seekers in formulating their requests. We also found that increased control and predictability in requests will be valued, especially in conditions where requests are less visible. Lastly, our participants recognized the potential learning of offering support when others’ requests are visible. This observation suggests that platforms should consider mechanisms to showcase successful support exchanges,

which can enhance members' self-efficacy in offering help and their psychological comfort in receiving support.

Future research could explore the nuanced trade-offs associated with anonymity affordances, obscuring the support requester's identity. This investigation could focus on how anonymity might reduce the social costs associated with asking for help, yet potentially impact the sense of belonging within a community.

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A SCENARIOS

Scenario 1: You opened your credit card statement for this month, the bill is twice as large as it usually is. It turns out the bank didn't process your payment from last month. In addition to a \$100 late fee, you have been charged a 22% interest rate on last month's bill. You are unsure whether you can afford to pay off the entire bill this month. If you do not, you will again be charged a high interest rate on the remaining amount, which could total well over \$1000. You want to ask someone to borrow some money to help manage this unexpected financial strain.

Scenario 2: It's Wednesday afternoon, and you've just received an interview offer from the company you applied to. This last minute interview is scheduled tomorrow at 9 AM that you absolutely can't miss. You get a call from your regular babysitter, informing you that she got the flu and won't be able to watch your 5-year-old son, Max, tomorrow. With your partner out of town and no immediate family nearby, you're in a bind. You want to ask someone to look after your child for a few hours.

Scenario 3: The contractors inform you that for the next three days, your water and electricity will be shut off, making it nearly impossible to stay at home. You start searching local AirBnB listings and nearby hotel rates. The least expensive hotel room you can find is going for \$250 a night, and the only available AirBnB property is a luxury apartment listed at a pricy rate. You want to ask someone if they have a spare room where you could crash for a few nights.

B SUPPORT REQUEST INTERVENTIONS

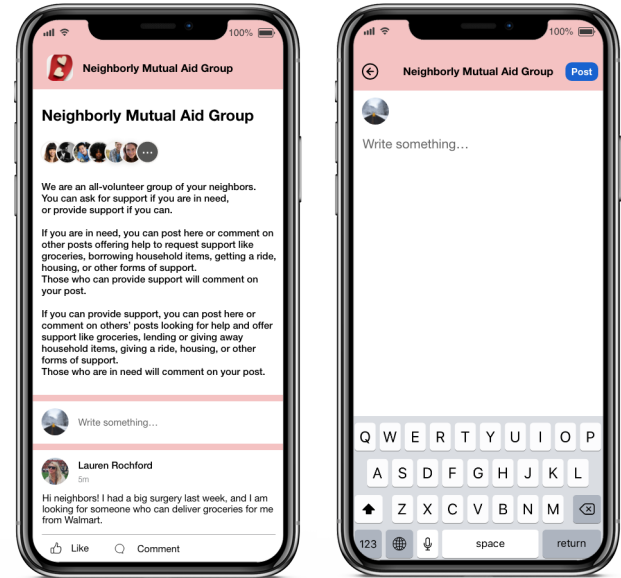


Figure 2: Highly Visibility

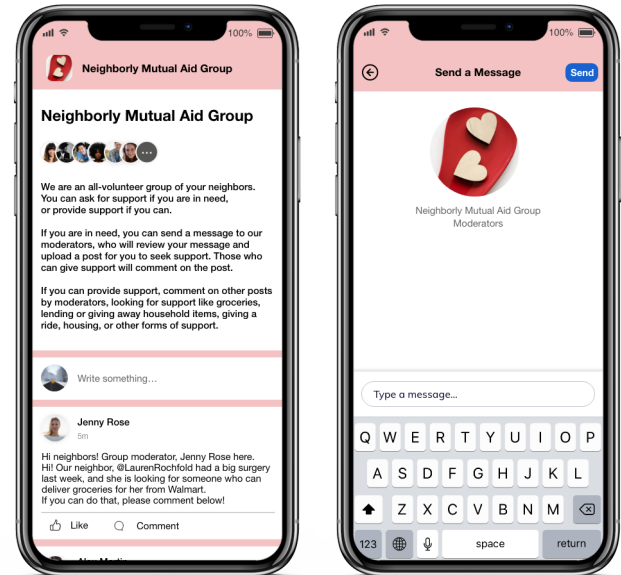


Figure 3: Moderate Visibility

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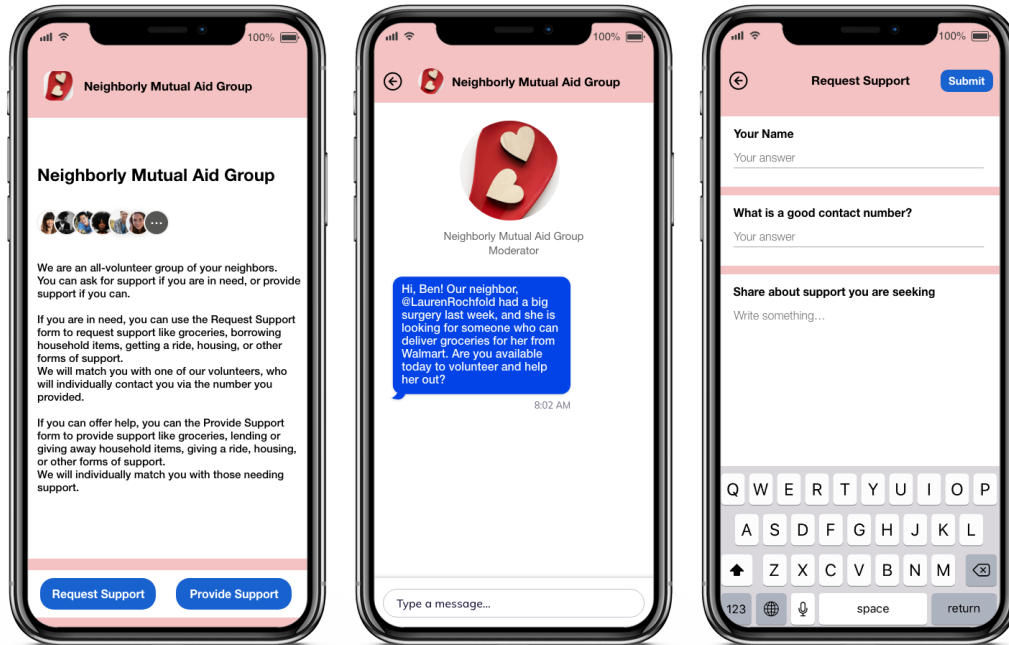


Figure 4: Low Visibility